# Singapore

Clean, Green and Mean (in a good way) Modern, Opulent, Energetic. A model for urban planning and original in addressing affordable housing. Government working for the people (what a novelty). Everything is huge: skyscrapers, malls, underground, bridges, apartment towers. Hugely conscious about security everywhere: trains, airport, Casinos ( a full Monty of fingerprints, face recognition and more) Traffic and transportation are swift and efficient. Gardens, flowers, trees in and on every building. Seems like the people are happy and proud of what they achieved in just less than 60 years. Harmonious relations albeit in allocated areas of the three ethnicities: Chinese, Indian and Malai. China Town, Little India and Malay District. A wonderful place in a turbulent world. We haven't been out much since the pandemic began so it may have changed in Toronto as well but the overwhelming impression is that every man, women and (especially) child have their head buried in their Smartphones ALL the time. Going up or down on escalators, on the subway, in restaurants and just walking in the streets. Also everything from security to ordering food are powered with QR . If you don't have a smartphone in Singapore, don't leave your house.

# SUKAU

# Kinabatangan River

Our two days in  (name) were mostly spent on the river((video) in a small but powerful boat we went on 3 river cruises to spot wild life. First were monkeys all 4 species in Malaysia as you can see and plenty of them (pics). On the second we discovered crocodile (one but huge) a rare site of Orang-utans in the wild and on the third we struggled to find anything until we discovered lone elephant female and her baby feeding of the “elephant grass” on the riverbank. But the highlight of the day was a complimentary home cooking luncheon at a local family home. The decor inside and outside was originally local and the food and hospitality superb. (pics) We are now inside a 4x4 luxury van headed deep into the famous Danum Valley on a rugged dirt road for three hours.

# Danum Valley Rain Forest

We now know the answer: Hiking in the rainforest is not a geriatric sport. Mom fell down on her 17th step and again an hour later. You have to hand it to her as she endured a difficult steep terrain without difficulty except for occasionally keeping her balance. Breathing, back and legs were a OK. Me I lost my breath and was gasping for a section of the trail but recovered.

Let's face it we're 80 years old damn it!

# Kyoto-Japan

Today we decided to take the hop on and hop off city tour which has 14 stations with the most popular city tour attractions. Some we have already seen in the first three days so we stopped at only 3 more and in doing so discovered the magnificent imperial castle with its breath taking gardens. In sum for Kyoto: great experience, good planning of things we enjoy seeing or experiencing and in the proper sequence from day to day. Well worth the travel if not the shekels (in as much that Japan we found is less expensive than Toronto but ours is a small and

unique sample. Heading over to Tokyo and another exhausting all travel day to Malaysia.

The highlight of the day was a 10 course 3 hours Japanese traditional Keisaki lunch. It will probably remain the highlight of our trip. Learning from Erin we took pictures of every dish prepared for the seven of us. Yes, only eight seats (one was a single) by a master chef. We were sitting on bar stools in front of a special kitchen (see pictures) where the chef a sue chef and a hostess prepared and plated all 10 courses. It included all sort of local seasonal ingredients: greens, fish, oysters, tempura sardines and wagyu beef. We have never had a meal like this anywhere in the world. Put it this way: we have a video of Safta that will likely go viral showing her using chopsticks and eating authentic Japanese food and… enjoying it!

>> The serving are so delicately plated like a work of art. We were the only Israeli Canadian Jewish patrons the other all Japanese. The chef himself barely speaks English but still managed to explain the ingredients. OK it is just over $300+ for lunch but the experience AND the food were unforgettable.
> We were planning to go out tonight to the Gion district that really is coming alive at night but mom's back reused to join so we have a quiet evening in the hotel and still managed 6632 steps.

Our second day in Kyoto was by young people standards a relatively light day. Breakfast at the hotel. ( great choice,

wonderfully helpful staff) a short walk to the market on a Saturday morning. We saw food we have never seen before or knew existed. Just watch the pictures. We then went to a demonstration and tasting of a traditional tea making ceremony. There are tea making schools in Japan. Very exclusive (only 5 couples in a tiny room) and pristine. The making of Matcha is an extremely intricate ritual with a symbolic set of soul calming actions culminating in drinking the Matcha. We then walked around the bustle of the famous Gion district known as Geisha town ( likely for a reason) after discovering that the Kyoto National Museum had only one (Buddhist) exhibit and is under renovations. Yesterday we thought that we would not "need" to see another Temple but it was highly recommended to us so we did. It was even more spectacular than the four we have seen yesterday. Watch some awesome pictures of the temple (save you the long Japanese name). In particular the one where mom is watching the temple complex high above holding her back and whispering NFW. But soldiering through broken as she is. There are no limit to mom's bravery.
Back at the hotel after an "easy" and wonderful day for a Sake tasting ceremony.

"They" say that first impression are also last impressions. Our first impression is that Japan is not a tourist friendly country notwithstanding that the Japanese people are very courteous if not friendly. More specifically it is not an OLD people friendly. The signage is confusing overwhelmingly Japanese and staff is

not well informed went it comes to direction and mostly non English speaking in major airports and train stations. This made for a hellish travel day of trains, planes and automobiles and 29 hours from door to door of our hotel in Kyoto. As usual I lost it when no one could direct us to Arrivals after a 14 hours flight from New York and we walked miles with our bags all over the huge Narita airport. I specifically mentioned old people as Japan is obsessed with QR codes through Apps all which require Wi-Fi login and 2 ways verification and switching screens to locate security code to retrieve our reserved for weeks seats on the bullet train to Kyoto. By the time we arrived at the hotel we found the gates locked up with no instructions where and how to enter the hotel only to find out after a few hectic moments with the help of walkers by that the night regime is in effect and entrance is only through a hidden side entrance. Who knew?

Second first impression: Japanese are colorless. Contrary to their colorful traditional dress like the kimono their day to day dress is black and white with an occasional grey and that goes for men women and children. If you happen to see someone with flashy colours it is a 100% a tourist. But enough of critique (as I tell Safta from time to time)

The first full day in Kyoto we did the obligatory tour of the must see temples and shrine in an 8 hours marathon of an organized tour and 18,579 steps. Awesome. Only the pictures can best tell the story. Safta braved her way through all of it step by (slow) step toward the end in the face of what she described as excruciating pain. The woman is one of a kind for bravery and

all other things you already know about her. Tired to the point of breakage the first full day was well worthwhile including a genuine Japanese lunch.